

**FERN & FEATHER**

*Counseling and Wellness*

# Anxiety Toolkit

12 evidence-based coping skills  
you can use right now.

*Grounding, breathing, and relaxation techniques  
science-backed and trauma-informed.*

*Cut along the dotted lines and carry these  
cards in your wallet as a quick reset.*

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## BREATHING

1

### 4-7-8 Breathing

- Inhale through your nose for 4 seconds
- Hold your breath for 7 seconds
- Exhale through your mouth for 8 seconds
- Repeat 4 cycles

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## GROUNDING

2

### 5-4-3-2-1 Grounding

- 5 things you can SEE
- 4 things you can HEAR
- 3 things you can TOUCH
- 2 things you can SMELL
- 1 thing you can TASTE

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## BREATHING

3

### Box Breathing

- Inhale for 4 seconds
- Hold for 4 seconds
- Exhale for 4 seconds
- Hold empty for 4 seconds
- Repeat 4 times

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## AWARENESS

4

### Body Scan

- Start at your toes, move upward
- Notice each body part in turn
- Observe sensations without judgment
- End at the top of your head

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## RELAXATION

5

### Muscle Relaxation

- Squeeze one muscle group tight
- Hold for 5 seconds, then release
- Work from feet to forehead
- Let tension melt away

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## NERVOUS SYSTEM

6

### Cold Water Reset

- Splash cold water on your face
- Or hold an ice cube in your hand
- Activates the parasympathetic system
- Brings calm in 30-60 seconds

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## IMAGERY

7

### Safe Place Visualization

- Picture a place where you feel safe
- Engage all five senses
- What do you see, hear, smell, feel?
- Stay here for 2-3 minutes

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## SELF-CARE

8

### Self-Compassion Break

- Name it: "This is hard right now"
- Normalize: "I am not alone in this"
- Be kind: "May I be gentle with myself"
- Rest a hand over your heart, breathe

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#### DBT SKILL

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### Opposite Action

- Notice what your emotion urges
- Do the OPPOSITE with intention
- Anxious? Reach out to someone
- Depressed? Get moving gently

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#### QUICK RESET

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### Sigh Breath

- Take a deep inhale through nose
- Take one more sip of air on top
- Exhale slowly through your mouth
- Drop your shoulders. Repeat x3

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#### DEFUSION

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### Label the Thought

- Notice a distressing thought
- Add: "I am having the thought that..."
- Creates distance - you are not your thoughts
- Let the thought pass like a cloud

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#### SOMATIC

12

### Butterfly Hug

- Cross your arms over your chest
- Tap alternately: left, right, left
- Like butterfly wings on your heart
- Breathe slowly. Calms the nervous system

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# About This Toolkit

These 12 coping skills are drawn from evidence-based therapeutic approaches including CBT, DBT, somatic therapy, and mindfulness-based stress reduction.

They are not a substitute for professional care, but they can help you regulate your nervous system in moments of stress, anxiety, or overwhelm.

We use these same techniques with our clients every day. We hope they bring you a little more calm, groundedness, and self-compassion.

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*Please note: This toolkit is for educational purposes and is not a substitute for professional mental health treatment. If you are in crisis, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline) or go to your nearest emergency room.*